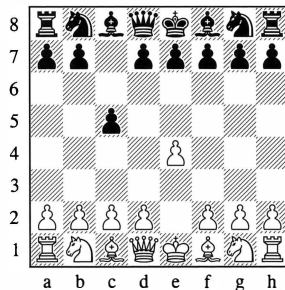


# Chapter 1

## Various 2nd Moves



### Rare Options

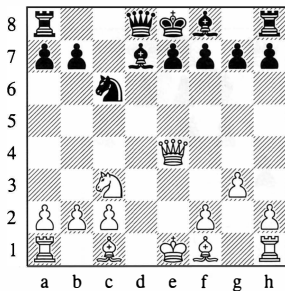
### Variation Index

1.e4

1...c5

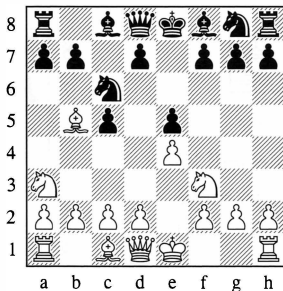
|                                            |    |
|--------------------------------------------|----|
| A) 2.♙c4                                   | 8  |
| B) 2.c4                                    | 9  |
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| D) 2.♘a3 ♘c6                               | 13 |
| D1) 3.♙b5                                  | 13 |
| D2) 3.♘f3                                  | 14 |
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| F1) 4.c3?!                                 | 21 |
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C) after 9.♙e4!



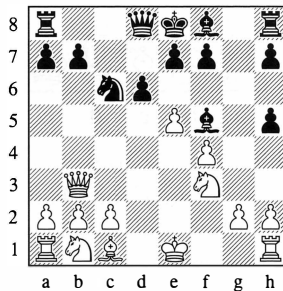
9...g6!N

D1) note to 4.d3!N



4...♘ge7!N

E2) after 10.♘f3



10...♙g7?!N

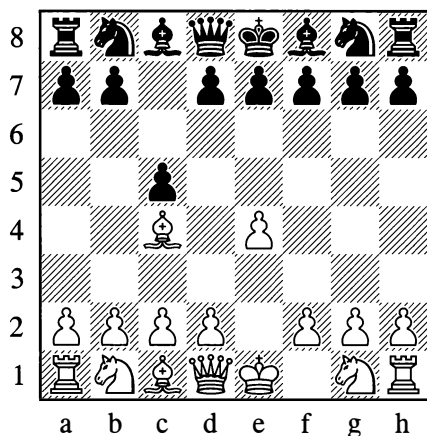
**1.e4 c5**

This chapter will concentrate on the rare moves: **A) 2.♖c4**, **B) 2.c4**, **C) 2.♘e2**, **D) 2.♘a3**, **E) 2.f4** and **F) 2.a3**.

2.d4 cxd4 3.c3 gives us a choice: the solid 3...♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 enters the c3 Sicilian (see Chapters 5 to 9), while accepting the gambit with 3...dxc3 4.♘xc3 ♘c6 5.♘f3 g6 transposes to variation A of Chapter 19 on page 343.

2.♗e2 is likely to transpose elsewhere, e.g. 2...♘c6 3.f4 d5 4.d3 is line B12 of Chapter 2.

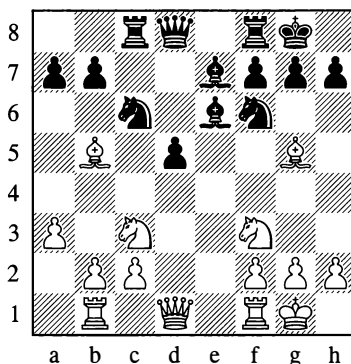
2.a4 is a strange-looking move, but it has some point to it, although I struggle to believe you will face it regularly in tournament play. 2...♘c6 3.♗b5 ♘f6 4.♘c3 g6 5.♘f3 ♗g7 6.0-0 0-0 7.d3 d6 8.h3 a6 9.♗xc6 bxc6 10.♖b1 ♖e8= was fine for Black in Quaddy – Neapus, engine game 2011, which was agreed drawn an emotionally-draining 115 moves later.

**A) 2.♖c4**

This is rather harmless, as the bishop will be an object of attack on c4 and will have to move again. Black will be allowed to obtain good development.

**2...e6! 3.♖e2**

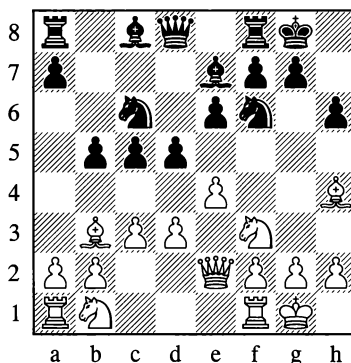
3.♘f3 ♘f6! 4.♘c3 (4.e5 d5! 5.exf6 dxc4 6.fxg7 ♗xg7 7.♖e2 [7.♘a3 e5!] 7...♘c6 8.♖xc4 b6! 9.0-0 ♖g8!→ was better for Black in Osipov – Rimkus, corr. 2010) 4...♘c6 5.0-0 d5 6.exd5 exd5 7.♗b5 ♗d6 8.d4 0-0 9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.♗g5 ♗e6 11.♖b1 ♖c8 12.a3 ♗e7 Bersamina – Kantans, Pune 2014, and now:



13.♖e1!N= (Instead, 13.♘d4?! should have led to a slight pull for Black after 13...♘xd4!N 14.♖xd4 a6 15.♗e2 ♖e8+ as the c3-knight is clumsy and White is blockading the d5-pawn with the wrong piece.)

**3...♘c6 4.♘f3**

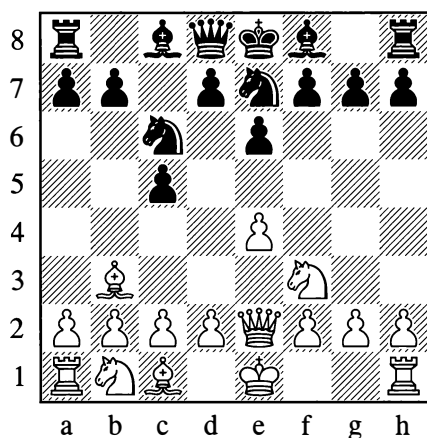
4.c3 ♗e7 5.♗b3 d5 6.d3 ♘f6 7.♘f3 0-0 8.0-0 b5 9.♗g5 (9.♗c2 b4+ 9...h6!? (9...c4 10.dxc4 bxc4 11.♗a4 dxe4 12.♗xc6 exf3 13.♗xf3 ♖b8 14.♗f4 ♖b5 15.b4 ♘d5 16.♗g3 ♗f6 17.a4 ♖xb4 18.cxb4 ♗xa1 19.♖xc4 ♗b7 20.♘a3 ♗c3+ was a wild affair that eventually ended in Black's favour in Rasik – Smirin, Czech Republic 2003.) 10.♗h4



10...a5!? 11.e5 ♖d7 12.♙xe7 ♖xe7 In my opinion Black has an excellent position. He has a lot of space on the queenside, offering him promising chances in that sector of the board.

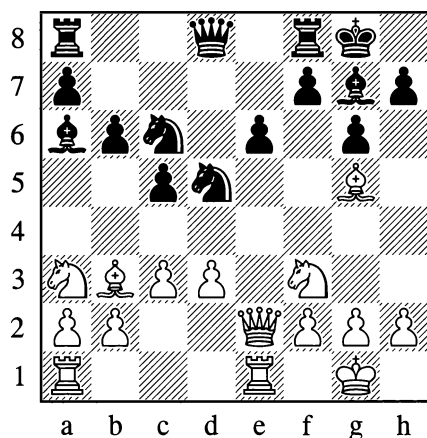
#### 4...♖ge7!? 5.♙b3

5.d3 ♖g6 6.h4!? (6.0–0 ♙e7 7.c3 d5 8.♙b3 0–0 is great for Black) 6...♙d6! 7.♖bd2 h6 8.h5 ♖ge5 9.♖xe5 ♙xe5 10.♖f3 ♙b8!? 11.c3 0–0 12.♙b3 d5 is fine for us.



5...g6!? 6.c3 ♙g7 7.d3 b6 8.0–0 ♙a6 9.♙e1 0–0 10.♖a3 d5 11.exd5 ♖xd5 12.♙g5

Black had the more harmonious development in Rasik – Jirovsky, Karlovy Vary 2004, and should have now chosen:



#### 12...♙c7Nf

Black enjoys a slight edge due to the weakness of the d3-pawn.

#### B) 2.c4

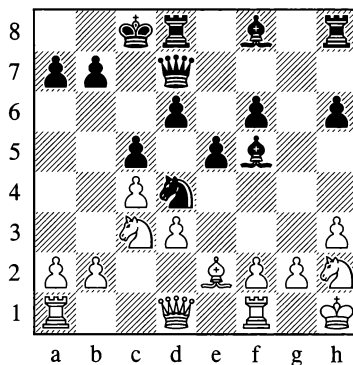
This will most likely transpose to an English Opening. Here we will look at possible deviations from White's perspective.

#### 2...♖c6 3.♖e2!?

Toying with the possibility of d2-d4, transposing to a Maroczy Bind.

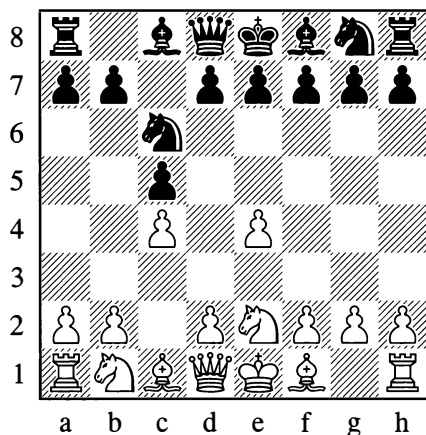
Instead, 3.♖c3 g6 leads to the English and is outside the scope of this book.

3.♖f3 e5 is obviously fine for Black, as the knight stands badly on f3. One recent example went: 4.♖c3 d6 5.d3 (5.g3 g6 6.♙g2 ♙g7 7.0–0 ♖ge7 8.d3 0–0 9.♖g5 f6 10.♖h3 ♙e6 11.f4 ♙d7 12.♖f2 ♖d4 13.♙e3 ♙ab8 was excellent for Black in Plueg – Shaw, Coulsdon 1997.) 5...f5!? 6.exf5 ♙xf5 7.h3?! ♙d7 8.♙e2 ♖f6 9.♖h2?! White is fighting for the light squares, but Black has enough resources to combat this plan. 9...♖d4 10.♙g5 0–0–0! 11.0–0 h6 12.♙xf6 gxf6 13.♖h1?! (13.♖d5!?, preparing to counterattack by b2-b4, might have made a fight of it.)



13...h5! 14.♙xh5 ♙e6 15.♖e2 ♖b8 16.♖xd4 cxd4 Black's attack eventually proved too

much for White in Karacsony – S. Petkov, corr. 2012.



### 3...♟f6!

It turns out that Black does not intend to simply reach the Maroczy. Again, the clumsy knight on e2 gives him the signal for a quick opening up of the centre.

### 4.♟bc3 e6! 5.d4 d5!

So, there we have it. The only one who seems to believe in White's chances here is the German player Amadeus Eisenbeiser, but practical examples suggest it is Black who has the easier game.

### 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♟g5

Eisenbeiser's trademark.

### 7.e5?!

This led to a quick disaster for White after:

### 7...♟g4! 8.f4?

8.h3 cxd4 9.♟xd4 ♟gxe5 10.♟f4 had to be preferred, although it is clear that White is struggling a pawn down.

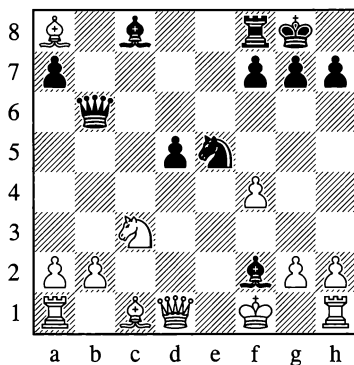
8...cxd4 9.♟xd4 ♟c5! 10.♟b5 0-0! 11.♟xc6 bxc6 12.♟xc6 ♟b6! 13.♟xa8 ♟f2† 14.♟e2 ♟xe5

14...♟h4!N+ would have been cleaner.

### 15.♟f1?

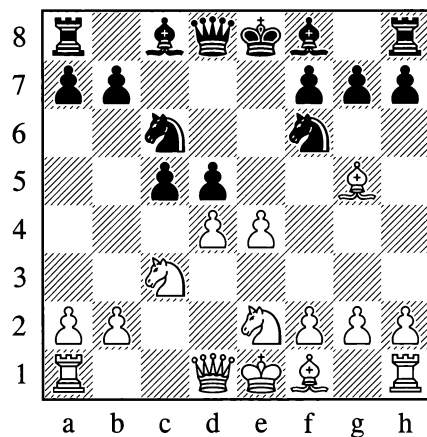
Better was 15.♟d2, although Black would

still gain a sizeable advantage after: 15...♟c4! 16.♟xd5 ♟e8† 17.♟e4 ♟d6! 18.♟xd6 ♟xd6 19.♟xf2 ♟b6† 20.♟e3 ♟xb2† 21.♟d2 ♟xe3 22.♟xe3 ♟c3† 23.♟f2 ♟xd2† 24.♟f3 ♟c3† 25.♟f2 g5!†



15...♟a6† 16.♟e2 ♟h4 17.g3 ♟g4 18.♟g2 ♟f2† 19.♟h3 ♟xe2 20.♟xd5 ♟f6 21.♟g2 ♟e8 22.♟xf2 ♟xf2† 23.♟g2 ♟xh1 24.♟c6 ♟e6 25.♟a4 ♟d4

0-1 Tukhvatullin – Karpeshov, Sterlitamak 2011.



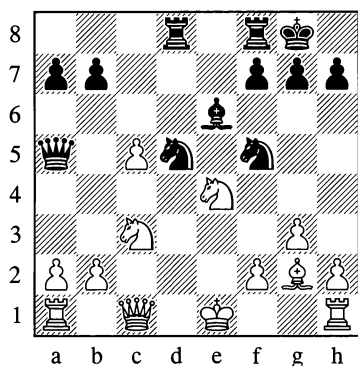
### 7...♟e7!

After this simple reply, it is rather White who is playing for equality. I think he can achieve it by:

### 8.♟xf6!?

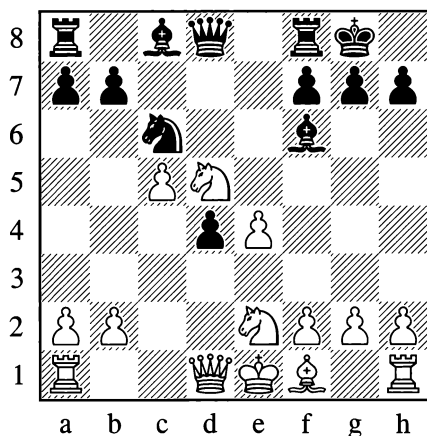
8.exd5 ♟xd5 9.♟xe7 ♟cxe7 10.dxc5 0-0

leaves the white king too exposed in the centre, and I don't like his chances at all. For example: 11.♖d2 (11.♖d4?! ♙e6 12.♘f4 ♘xf4 13.♖xf4 ♘d5! 14.♘d5 ♖xd5 15.♙e2 ♖xg2 16.♙f3 ♖g6+ left White in dire straits in Eisenbeiser – Solak, Dresden 2007.) 11...♙e6 12.♘e4 ♖c7! 13.g3 ♙ad8 14.♙g2 ♘f5 15.♖c1 ♖a5+ 16.♘2c3 Eminov – Yilmazyerli, Antalya 2013, and now:



16...♘c3!N 17.♖xc3 ♖a6 18.♙f1 ♖c6 19.♙g2 ♙d5 20.f3 ♘d4!+

8...♙xf6 9.dxc5 d4 10.♘d5 0-0



11.g3!N

Weaker is 11.♘xf6+ ♖xf6 12.♘g3 ♘e5! 13.♙d3 b6! 14.c6 (14.0-0? bxc5 15.♙e1 c4 16.♙f1 d3 17.♖d2 ♙b8+ was simply lost for White in Eisenbeiser – Fluvia Poyatos,

Barcelona 2007) 14...♖xc6 15.0-0 a5 16.♙c1 ♖d6+ when Black still maintains a nagging initiative.

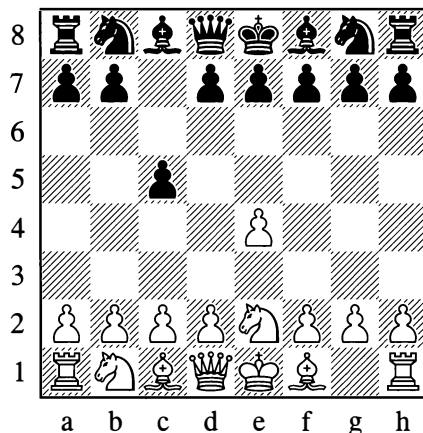
11...♙g4

11...d3 12.♘ec3 ♙xc3+ 13.bxc3 ♙e8 14.♖xd3 ♘e5 15.♖e3 produces another interesting position, where Black has a choice between 15...f5!? and 15...♘f3+ 16.♖xf3 ♖xd5 17.♙d3 ♖xc5 18.0-0 ♙e6.

12.♙g2 d3 13.♖xd3 ♙xb2 14.♙d1 ♖a5+ 15.♖d2 ♙a3 16.♖xa5 ♘xa5 17.h3 ♙e6 18.0-0 ♙xc5 19.♘ef4=

In this ending there is still plenty of play left for both sides, but the objective evaluation is equality: opposite-coloured bishops will soon appear on the board.

C) 2.♘e2



White is trying to postpone d2-d4 and create an awkward dilemma for Najdorf players: 2...♘c6 runs into 3.d4, while 2...d6 3.♘bc3 ♘f6 4.g3 could be luring them into a g3 Dragon or a Closed Sicilian with ...e6 (which is beyond the subject of this book). Therefore, I have decided to offer a more clear-cut solution, in an attempt to satisfy all tastes:

2...♘f6!? 3.♘bc3 d5!

That's it! Usually this pawn thrust would be premature, but the knight on e2 will prevent White from exploiting Black's opening of the centre.

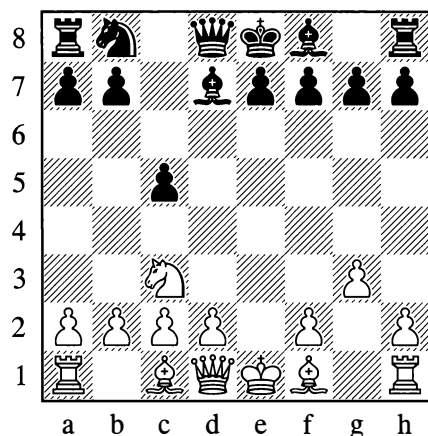
#### 4.exd5

I think that White has to take.

The alternative 4.e5 ♖g4 5.♗f4 (5.f4?! is better for Black after either 5...e6 or 5...h5) 5...♗xe5 6.♗fxd5 e6 7.♗e3 ♗bc6 8.g3 (8.f4 ♗g6 9.g3? ♗xf4!) 8...f5! 9.f4 ♗f7 10.♗g2 ♗d7 11.0-0 ♗e7 leads to a situation where Black's control over the d4-square easily guarantees him at least equal prospects.

#### 4...♗xd5 5.g3 ♗xc3 6.♗xc3 ♗d7!

Black is ready to bring his bishop to c6, so White must act.



#### 7.d4!

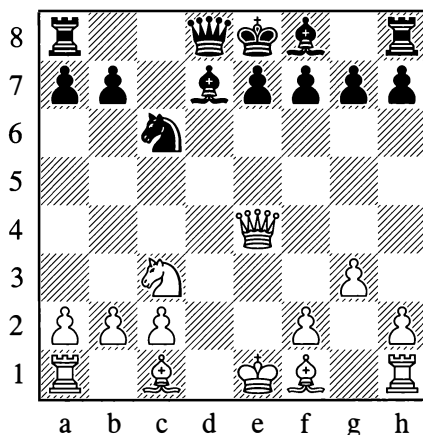
The only chance to develop an initiative.

#### 7...cxd4 8.♖xd4 ♗c6 9.♖e4!

An accurate choice of Hou Yifan's, keeping the queen in the centre without allowing Black the luxury of harassing it.

9.♖c4 allows 9...♗e6! 10.♖b5 (10.♖a4 ♖d4=) 10...a6! 11.♖xb7 ♗d4 12.♗d3 ♖b8 13.♖xa6 (13.♖g2 g6 14.0-0 ♗g7 15.♗xa6 0-0 16.♗d3 ♖c8) 13...♗f3† 14.♗d1 ♗e5 and Black

is not worse, in spite of his two-pawn deficit. A likely conclusion is a repetition after: 15.♗e1 (15.♗f4 ♗xd3 16.♖xd3 ♖xd3† 17.cxd3 ♖xb2 18.♗e3 g6 19.♗d4 f6= is okay for Black) 15...♗f3† 16.♗d1 ♗e5=



#### 9...g6!N

A strong idea: combining development with the creation of a good square on f5 for the bishop. Now Black has nothing to worry about.

In Hou Yifan – Ju Wenjun, Lopota 2014, Black continued with the weakening 9...f5?! 10.♖c4 ♗e5. After the further 11.♖d5! ♗c6 12.♖xe5 ♗xh1, Hou Yifan could have wrapped up the game with 13.♗b5!N ♖c8 14.♗xa7 ♖xc2 15.♖xf5+.

#### 10.♗g2 ♗g7 11.0-0 0-0 12.♖d1 ♖c8 13.♗e3 ♗f5 14.♖a4

14.♖h4 ♖d8 15.♖xd8† ♖xd8 16.♖d1 ♖e8=

#### 14...♗h3! 15.♗e4

15.♗h1 ♖g4=

#### 15...♗g4

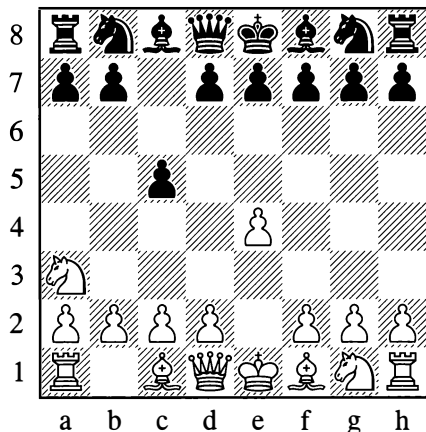
15...♗f5 16.♗h1 ♖b8 17.♖d2 ♗xc3 18.bxc3 ♗e5 19.♖xa7 ♖xc3 20.♖d4 ♖xd4 21.♖xd4 ♗c6 22.♖d2±

**16.♞d5**

16.♞d2 ♞e5=

**16...♞e6=**

The chances look to be completely equal.

**D) 2.♞a3**

A rather weird move, designed to keep the c-pawn unblocked in order to use it in the fight for the centre later on. The other major accomplishment of having the knight on a3 is that it controls the c4-square, which means that, according to circumstance, White may try to turn it into either a base or a transfer point for the sidelined beast.

**2...♞c6**

I consider this logical reply as the best possibility for Black, although plenty of other good ones exist.

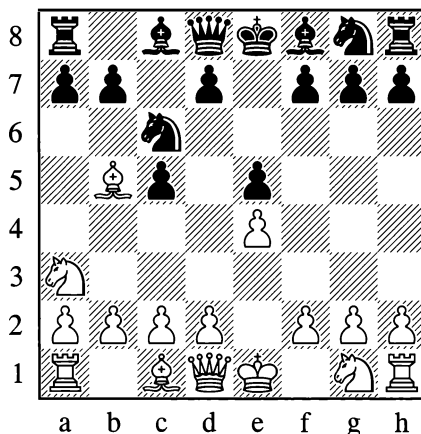
We will consider two moves for White: **D1) 3.♞b5** and **D2) 3.♞f3**.

**D1) 3.♞b5**

A move which has some purpose, especially as jumping to d4 with the c6-knight is less appealing without a knight standing on c3. My preference for Black is an almost untried move:

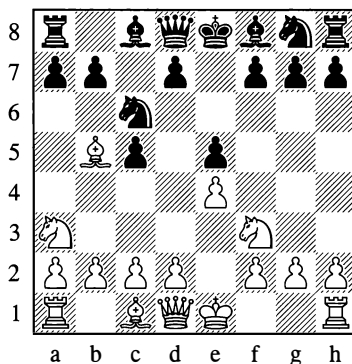
**3...e5!?**

This logical approach has been tried in only a handful of games so far, but I believe it offers the best practical chances and is also strategically sound: it will be a long time before the a3-knight can obtain access to the d5-square.

**4.d3!N**

The only testing move.

Saule – Jemec, email 2006, continued with 4.♞f3, and here I would like to suggest a new idea:

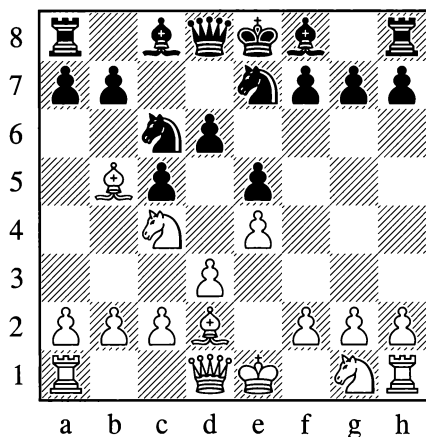


4...♞ge7!N 5.♞c4 (5.0–0 a6 6.♞e2 d5 7.exd5 ♞xd5 8.♞e1 f6 9.♞f1 ♞e7+ looks quite unimpressive for White) 5...d6 6.♞e3 a6 7.♞e2 d5 8.d3 d4 9.♞c4 ♞g6 10.a4 ♞e6+ The position is simply excellent for Black.

4.♙xc6 dxc6 5.♘c4 (5.♘f3 b5!? 6.d3 ♔d6 7.♘b1 h6 8.a4 ♙e6 is in no way better for White as Black will transfer his knight to d7, defending everything.) 5...♙e6 6.♚e2 ♚c7 7.a4 ♘e7 8.♘f3 f6= gives Black the perfect Rossolimo set-up.

#### 4...♘ge7 5.♘c4 d6 6.♙d2!

Preventing Black from playing ...a6 and gaining the bishop pair. Without this move White would be worse.



#### 6...♘g6!

6...a6?! 7.♙a5 ♚d7 8.♘b6 ♚c7 9.♙a4!± is not the kind of bind we'd like to fall into.

#### 7.♘e3 ♙e7 8.♘f3

Both 8.a4 ♙g5 9.♘f3 ♙xe3 10.♙xe3 0-0 and 8.♘d5 0-0 9.♘e2 ♙g5 are level.

#### 8...0-0 9.0-0

So far, the moves have been rather obvious for both sides. A simple equalizing idea is:

#### 9...♘d4!?

9...♙e6 10.♙c4 h6 11.♘d5 ♚d7 12.a4 ♙d8=, planning ...♘ce7, is also quite good.

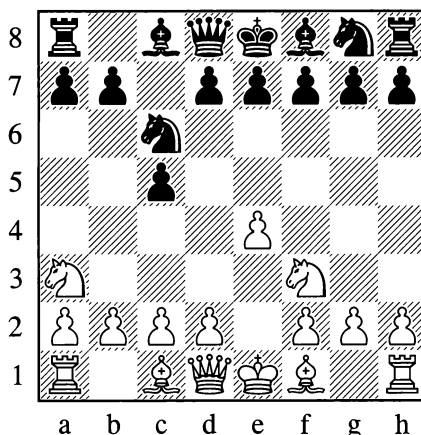
#### 10.♙c4

10.♘xd4 cxd4 11.♘d5 ♙e6 12.♙c4 ♙g5 13.g3 ♙xd2 14.♚xd2 ♘e7=

#### 10...♘xf3† 11.♚xf3 ♙g5! 12.a4 ♙e6=

Black has typically contested d5, getting rid of all his problems.

#### D2) 3.♘f3



The most obvious developing move.

#### 3...♘f6

With the knight on a3 this looks excellent, as e4 is now under attack.

#### 4.e5

The only try; without this move White obviously has nothing.

4.d3 g6 5.g3 ♙g7 6.♙g2 0-0 7.0-0 d5 8.exd5 ♘xd5 9.♙e1 b6 10.♘c4 ♙b7 11.h4 h6 12.♘ce5 ♚c7 13.♘xc6 ♙xc6= was fine for Black in Gallinnis – Kabatianski, Germany 2007.

#### 4...♘g4 5.♚e2

The correspondence player Hynes has been the chief exponent of this position as White, but he barely managed to scrape half a point out of his last two encounters with it.

#### 5...f6!?

A drastic solution – and a good one it seems.

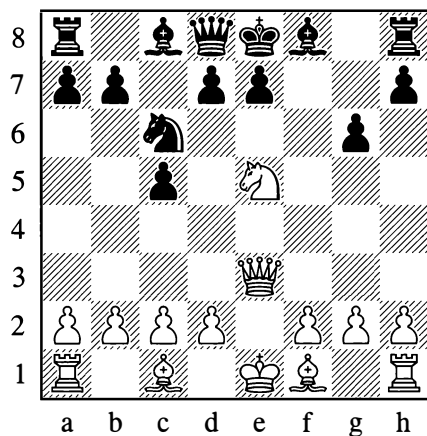


Alternatively, 5...♖c7 6.♘c4 e6 7.h3 ♘h6 8.d4 cxd4 9.♙xh6 gxh6 10.♖d2 ♙b4 11.c3 b5 12.♘d6† ♙xd6 13.exd6 ♖xd6 14.♙xb5 ♖c5 15.♙e2 dxc3 16.bxc3 ♖g8 17.0–0 ♖b8? was double-edged in Hynes – Isigkeit, corr. 2008.

6.♘c4 ♘gxe5 7.♘cxe5 fxe5 8.♘xe5 g6!? 9.♖e3?!

This looks dubious.

9.♘xc6! dxc6! 10.♖e5! (10.h4 ♖d5 is fine for Black) 10...♖d4 11.♖xd4 cxd4 12.♙c4 b5 13.♙e2 (13.♙b3 d3) 13...♙e6= may look a shade better for White, but in fact the position is just balanced: Black has a lot of space and will keep his e-pawn on e7, where it is safely defended.

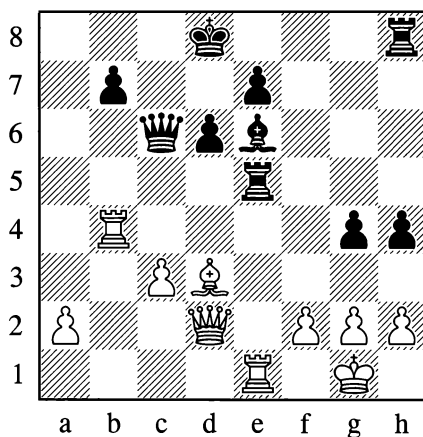


9...♘d4! 10.♖f4 ♖b6! 11.♖f7† ♘d8 12.♙d3 d6 13.♘f3 ♙e6 14.♖f4 ♙g7 15.♘xd4 ♙xd4 16.c3 g5!

White's attack lacks the ingredients of success and has obviously backfired. I will present the remaining moves of the game, as Black plays instructively.

17.♖f3 ♙e5 18.0–0 g4 19.♖e2 h5 20.b4 cxb4 21.♖b1 a5 22.cxb4 axb4 23.♙b2 ♖a5! 24.♙c3 ♙xc3 25.dxc3 ♖e5 26.♖d2 h4! 27.♖xb4 ♖c6 28.♖e1

28.♖fb1!? must be an improvement.



28...h3! 29.♙f1 ♖hh5! 30.♖eb1 ♙f5 31.♖1b2 ♙e4 32.♖b6 ♖d7 33.g3 ♖f5→

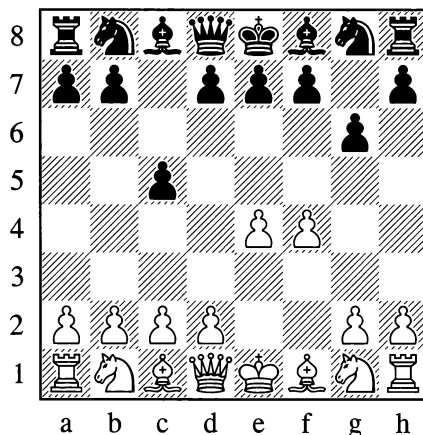
Black was doing all the attacking and went on to win a nice game in Hynes – Benlloch Guirau, corr. 2008.

### E) 2.f4

In this way, White avoids placing his knight on c3 for the moment; after 2...♘c6?! 3.♘f3 g6 4.♙b5 he would achieve his aim of obtaining a favourable version of the Rossolimo Variation.

### 2...g6

Black declares his intention of transposing into lines analysed under 2.♘c3.



**3.d4!?**

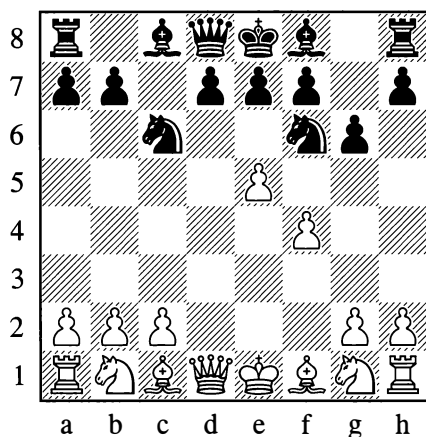
Leading the game to relatively untrodden paths.

3.♟f3 ♖g7! Waiting for White to put his knight on c3 before resorting to ...♟c6. 4.♟c3 ♟c6 A Grand Prix proper has been reached.

**3...cxd4 4.♖xd4 ♟f6 5.e5 ♟c6**

White can retreat his queen with either

**E1) 6.♖d1** or **E2) 6.♖d3**.

**E1) 6.♖d1**

This has been sporadically played; White wishes to avoid being harassed by a subsequent ...♟f5. Now, however, Black can exploit the fact that e4 is no longer covered:

**6...♟e4!?**

Black places his knight on a wonderful central outpost. White may try to exchange the knight on e4, or ignore it, at least for the time being, and concentrate on development:

**E11) 7.♟d2** or **E12) 7.♟e3**.

7.♟f3N may well be best. A possible line of play is: 7...d6 (7...♖b6 8.♖e2 d5 9.♖e3!∞) 8.♖e2 (8.♟e3 transposes to the note on 8.♟f3?! in variation E12) 8...♟c5 9.♟e3 ♟e6 (9...♟g4!?: 9...♖b6 10.♖b5!±) 10.♟c3 dxe5 11.fxe5 ♟g7 12.♖d1 ♖a5 13.♖d5 ♖c7∞

**E11) 7.♟d2**

The attempt to exchange the knight leaves the queenside a bit bare, for example:

**7...♟xd2 8.♟xd2**

The natural move, but Black can now play ...d6 without worrying about weakening his pawn structure.

**8.♖xd2!N**

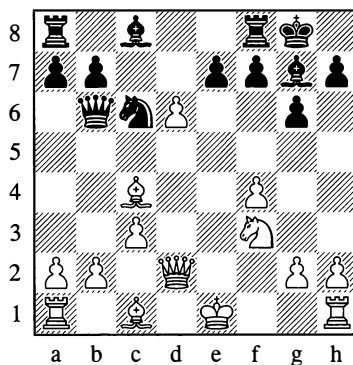
This is relatively best.

**8...d6! 9.exd6 ♟g7 10.♟f3!**

10.dxe7?! ♖xe7† 11.♟e2 (11.♖e3 ♟e6!± leaves White terribly exposed, as he is seriously lagging in development.) 11...0–0 12.♟f3 ♟f5!↑ Black has a tremendous initiative for the pawn.

**10...0–0 11.♟c4 ♖b6! 12.c3!?**

White might hold after 12.d7 ♟xd7 13.♖xd7 ♖ad8 14.♖g4 ♖b4† 15.♟d2 ♟xb2 16.♖b1 ♟xc1 17.♖xb4 ♟xd2† 18.♟f2 ♟xb4 19.♖d1 ♟c5† 20.♟f1 ♟d4±, but obviously Black has some chances to exploit the coordination of his pieces and the opponent's queenside weaknesses.



12...exd6 13.♖e3! ♖a5 14.0–0 d5 15.♟b3 ♟e6 16.♖f2!

16.♟d2?! ♖b5±

16...♖b5 17.♟e3 a5!

Black has excellent counterplay in the IQP position that has arisen, but White has an accurate reply:

18.♟f1!

White should have enough to maintain approximate equality.

8...♙g7 9.♙c3 d6 10.♘f3 0–0

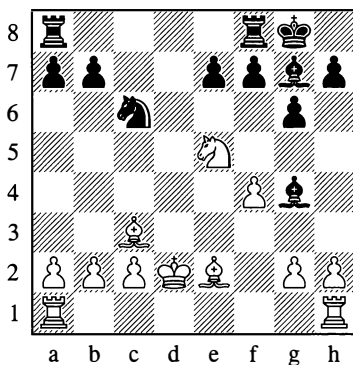
White is having difficulty maintaining control over e5, as the following variations show:

11.♙b5

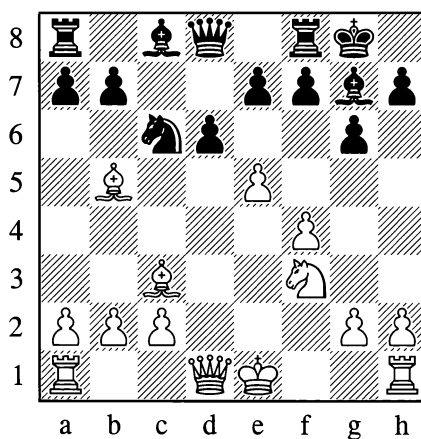
This is the most thematic move, but all the same Black manages to keep a degree of unpleasant pressure.

Weaker is instead 11.exd6?! ♙xc3† 12.bxc3 ♟a5!±.

11.♟d2!? might be tenable. I consider the following line to best for Black: 11...♙g4! 12.♙e2 (12.exd6?! ♙xc3! 13.♟xc3 ♟xd6 14.♘e5 ♘xe5 15.fxe5 ♟b6±) 12...dxe5 13.♘xe5 (13.♟xd8 ♟fxd8 14.♘xe5 ♙xe2 15.♘xe2 ♘d4†±) 13...♟xd2† 14.♘xd2



14...♙xe5! 15.fxe5 (15.♙xe5? ♘xe5 16.fxe5 ♙xe2 17.♘xe2 ♟ac8 18.c3 ♟c5–+) 15...♟fd8† 16.♙d3 ♙f5 17.♘e3 ♙xd3 18.cxd3 ♟d5 19.♘e4 ♟ad8 20.♟hd1 ♘g7± Black has good chances to press in the ending in view of his superior minor piece.



11...♟b6 12.♟e2 ♙g4 13.♙xc6!

This exchange is necessary.

Instead, 13.0–0–0 ♙h6! costs White a precious pawn for little compensation.

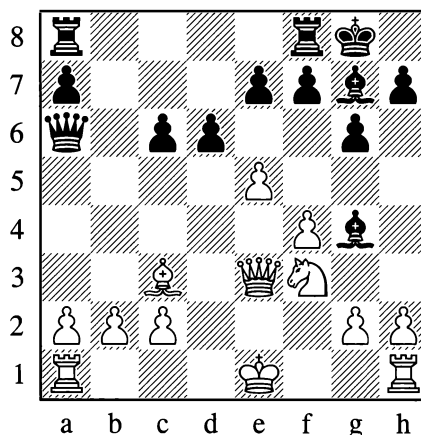
13...bxc6 14.♟f2! ♟a6!

Black insists on preventing White from castling.

15.♟e3

15.♟e2! was a better try, but after 15...♟a4!± Black maintains a nagging edge.

A good reply to 15.♟e3 is:



15...♙xf3 16.♟xf3 ♟ad8 17.♟e2 ♟b6 18.0–0–0 d5! 19.♟d2 ♟b8 20.♟d4 e6 21.♟xb6 axb6±

The ending was slightly better for Black due to his central mass, Salmensuu – Hillarp Persson, Reykjavik 2000.

### E12) 7. ♖e3 d6!?N

Trying to exploit the active e4-knight by opening up the position. White now faces a struggle to keep the balance.

7...d5

This leads to more static play, although Black should basically be okay; the move ...f6 can perhaps be employed at some point to liquidate the annoying e5-pawn.

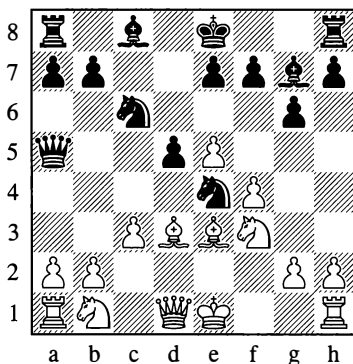
8. ♖d3

8. ♖f3!? ♖g4 9. ♖e2 ♖g7 10. 0–0 0–0 11. ♖bd2 ♖xd2 12. ♖xd2 ♖a5!? 13. c3!? (13. ♖xa5 ♖xa5=) 13...e6∞

8...♖a5†

8...♖f5 9. ♖f3 ♖g7 10. 0–0 0–0 11. ♖bd2 ♖c7=

9. c3 ♖g7 10. ♖f3

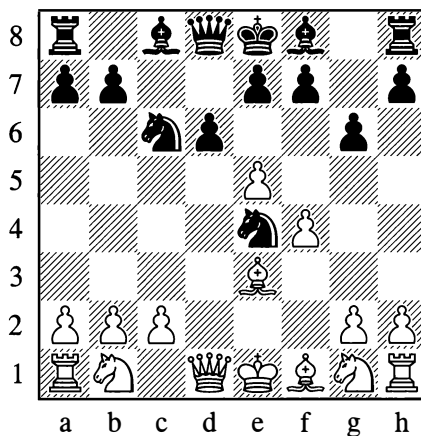


10...f6!? 11. exf6?!

11. 0–0!? 0–0 12. b4! ♖c7 13. ♖b3!± e.g. 13...e6 14. ♖xe4! dxe4 15. exf6 ♖xf6 16. ♖fd2 11...♖xf6 12. ♖bd2 ♖c7 13. ♖b3 0–0 14. ♖b5 ♖h8 15. ♖e2 ♖g4! 16. ♖d2 e5 17. h3 ♖f6 18. ♖xc6 bxc6 19. fxe5 ♖e4 20. ♖e3 ♖a6±

Black was better in Damljanovic – Z. Arsovic, Belgrade 1995. However, as was obvious from the comments, White could have improved earlier on.

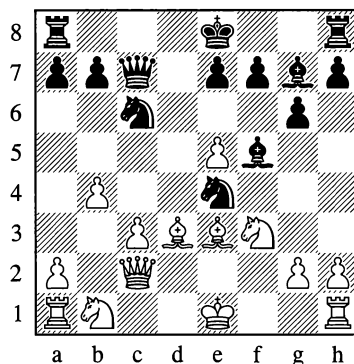
The following lines illustrate Black's potential:



8. ♖d3!?

Intriguing, but Black still comes out on top. Weaker is 8. ♖d5?! ♖f5 9. ♖b5 ♖c8± when White will be pushed back.

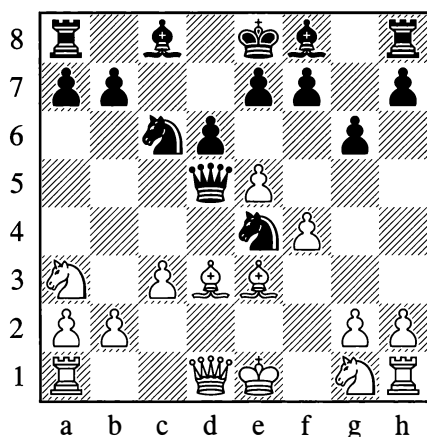
After 8. ♖f3?! ♖a5†! 9. c3 dxe5 10. fxe5 ♖g7 the e5-pawn looks fatally exposed. 11. b4?! (White is also worse after 11. ♖d3 ♖c5 12. ♖c4 ♖e6) 11...♖c7 12. ♖d3 ♖f5! White is in big trouble. For example: 13. ♖c2 (or 13. g4 0–0–0!! 14. gxf5 ♖xe5+ and White is about to be massacred along the open lines)



13...♖xc3!! 14. ♖xc3 (14. ♖xc3 ♖xe5 15. ♖xf5 ♖xf3† 16. gxf3 ♖xc3† 17. ♖f2 gxf5+–) 14...♖xd3 15. ♖xd3 ♖xe5 16. ♖b5† ♖d7 17. ♖d4 ♖xd4 18. ♖xd4 ♖c1† 19. ♖e2 ♖xh1 20. ♖xh8 ♖xg2+–

Finally, Black also ends up slightly better after:  
 8. ♖f3 f5! 9. exf6 ♘xf6 10. ♘c3 ♙g7 11. h3  
 (11. ♙c4 ♙g4! 12. ♖g3 d5 13. ♙e2 ♙f5↑ is  
 harmonious for Black) 11...0–0

8... ♖a5† 9. c3 ♖d5! 10. ♘a3?



10... ♘c5!

10... ♙f5?! 11. ♙c2±

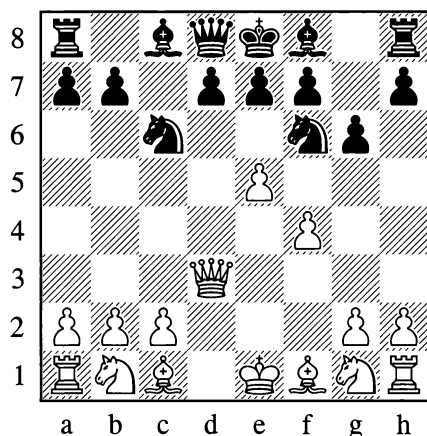
11. ♙xc5

11. ♙f1!? might be a better chance.

11... ♖xc5 12. ♘b5 ♖b8!?

Black is for preference.

E2) 6. ♖d3



White is trying to justify the queen sortie.

6... ♘h5?!

The knight is safely placed on the rim here:  
 it is important not to lose time by retreating  
 it to g8.

7. ♙e2

An attempt to exploit the knight's placement.

7. ♘f3 d6!

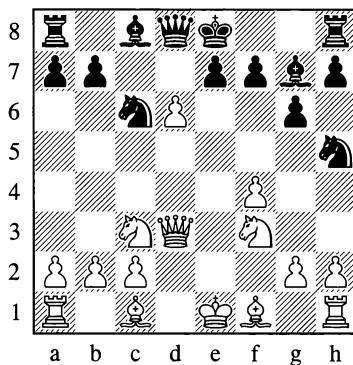
White has problems containing Black's  
 activity.

8. ♘c3

8. exd6 ♙f5! 9. dxe7?! ♖xe7† 10. ♖e3 0–0–0  
 11. ♙e2 ♖xe3 12. ♙xe3 ♙g7 13. c3 ♖he8  
 14. ♖f2 ♘f6+

8... ♙g7 9. exd6

9. ♙e3?! ♙f5 10. ♖b5 dxe5 11. ♘xe5 0–0  
 12. ♖d1 ♖b8! with the idea 13. ♘d7 ♙xd7  
 14. ♖xd7 ♘xf4! 15. ♖xb7 ♖d6 16. ♙xf4 ♖xf4  
 17. ♖xc6 ♙xc3† 18. bxc3 ♖fd8! 19. ♖d7  
 ♖ab8–+



9... ♙f5!?

Disturbing the coordination of White's  
 forces.

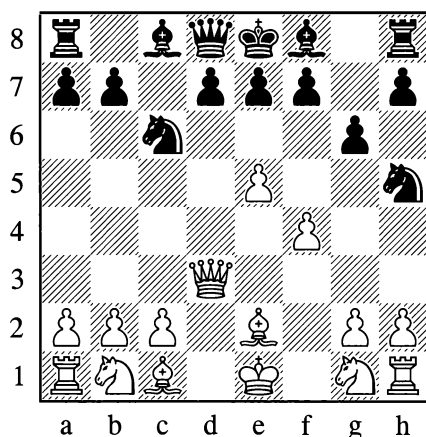
9...0–0 10. ♙e3 ♙f5 11. ♖d2∞ and White  
 breathes a lot easier.

10. dxe7 ♖xe7† 11. ♖e3 ♘b4!?

11... ♖xe3† 12. ♙xe3 0–0–0 13. ♖f2 ♖he8  
 14. ♙b5∞

12. ♙b5† ♖f8 13. ♖xe7†

13. ♖a4 ♖xc2!  
 13. ♖f2 ♜xc2 14. ♝xe7† ♖xe7 15. ♞b1 ♜d4  
 16. ♞a1 ♞hd8  
 13... ♖xe7 14. 0-0 ♜xc2 15. ♞b1 ♜d4 16. ♞a1  
 ♞hd8



### 7...d6!

Black ignores White's threat, as ...♙f5 will gain even more time.

### 8. ♖xh5 ♙f5 9. ♝b3

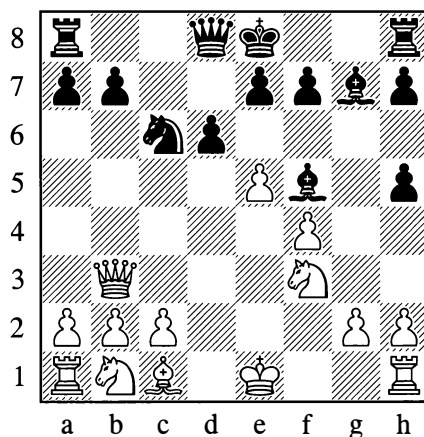
The solid choice.

After 9. ♝b5 gxf5 10. exd6 (10. ♝xb7 ♙e4! yields tremendous compensation for the pawn) 10... ♝d7! 11. ♜f3 (11. dxe7?! ♙xe7 12. ♜f3 0-0-0 13. 0-0 ♖xc2 14. ♝xh5 ♙g6! 15. ♝h6 ♞hg8→) 11... ♙e6! Black stands well.

### 9...gxf5 10. ♜f3 ♙g7! N

It seems more to the point to concentrate on development rather than lose time defending the pawn.

10... ♝d7 11. 0-0 ♙e6 happened in Westerinen – Arnason, Brighton 1981.



### 11. ♝xb7!?

11. 0-0 dxe5 12. fxe5 (12. ♝xb7 ♜d4! exchanges White's good knight on f3, giving Black the better prospects.) 12... ♜xe5 13. ♜xe5 ♝d4† 14. ♖h1 ♝xe5 15. ♜c3 0-0 16. ♝xb7 (16. ♙f4 ♝c5!?) 16... ♙e6 Black is fine in view of his two bishops.

### 11...♞c8

Black has excellent compensation in return for the pawn.

## F) 2.a3

White prepares b2-b4, with the idea of attacking the pawn on c5. If Black then replies with ...cxb4, that helps White achieve a central pawn preponderance. However, in practice things are not simple.

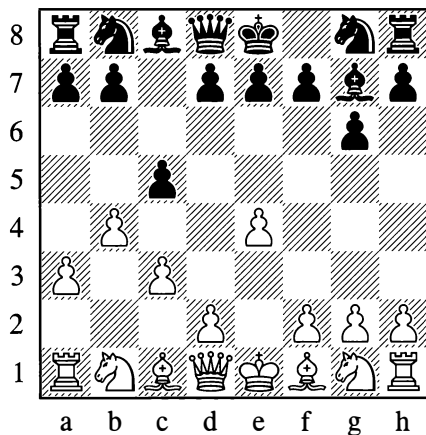
### 2...g6!

It is a traditional idea to meet similar flank attacks by fianchettoing the king's bishop.

### 3.b4 ♙g7

We will check the dubious F1) 4.c3?! before moving on to the main line with F2) 4. ♜c3!.

F1) 4.c3?!



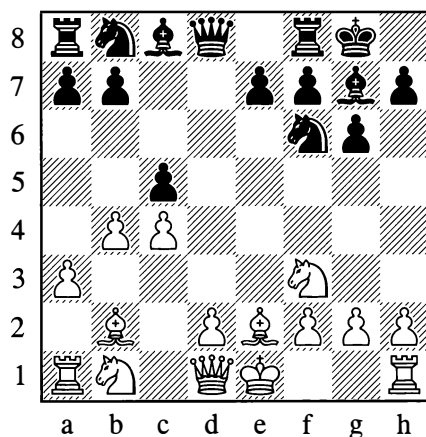
This impedes the knight's development and weakens the light-square complex in the centre.

4...d5! 5.exd5 ♖xd5 6.♟f3 ♟f6 7.♙e2 0-0

Black is threatening ...c4, so White's response is practically forced.

8.c4 ♜d8 9.♙b2!

9.bxc5? e5!±



9...b6! 10.0-0 ♙b7 11.d4!N

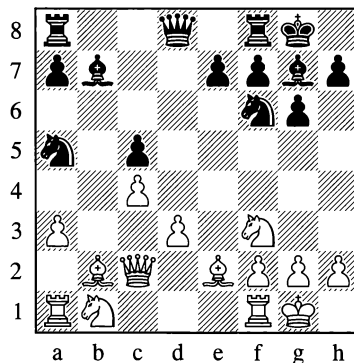
11.♞b3?

White is preparing ♞d1 followed by d2-d4, but it proves too slow.

11...♟c6! 12.bxc5

12.♞d1 e5! 13.♟xe5 ♟d4±

12...♟a5 13.♞c2 bxc5 14.d3



14...♟h5! 15.♙xg7 ♟xg7 16.♟bd2 ♟e6  
17.♞ab1 ♞c7 18.♞fe1 ♟c6 19.♟b3 a5!±

Black went on to win a model game in Mamedyarov – Kotronias, Calvia (ol) 2004.

11...cxd4 12.♟xd4

12.♙xd4 ♟c6 13.♙b2 ♞xd1 14.♞xd1 ♟e4!  
15.♙xg7 ♟xg7±

12...♟e4

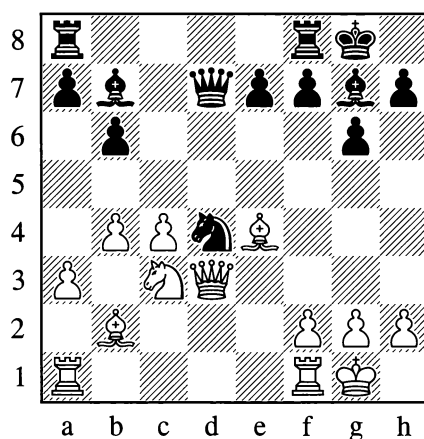
White has made too many pawn moves, which allows Black's better-developed army to take the leading role in the proceedings.

13.♙f3 ♞d7! 14.♞d3 ♟c6! 15.♙xe4

15.♞xe4 ♟xd4 16.♞xb7 ♟xf3† 17.♞xf3  
♙xb2 18.♞a2 ♙e5±

15...♟xd4 16.♟c3

16.♙xb7 ♞xb7 17.♙xd4? ♞fd8!

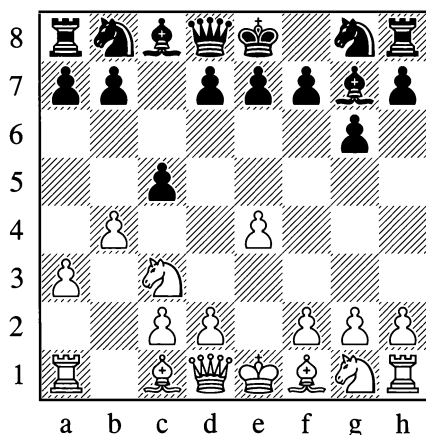


16...♙xe4 17.♖xe4

17.♘xe4 ♜fd8 18.c5 ♖g4!

17...♖c6 18.♖xe6 ♘xe6

F2) 4.♘c3!



The critical move: White intends to bring the rook to b1, support the pawn on b4, and thus complete the Bayonet Attack set-up. White will then try to develop the kingside, either by ♙c4 and ♘f3, or with a fianchetto of the king's bishop.

4...b6!

The most solid move available to Black, maintaining the central equilibrium.

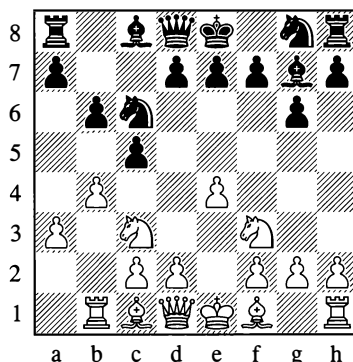
5.♘f3

After 5.g3 ♘c6 6.♖b1 e6! (6...d6 7.♙g2 e5 8.♘ge2 ♘ge7 9.0-0 0-0 10.d3 ♘d4 11.bxc5 bxc5 12.f4 ♙e6 13.f5! gxf5 14.exf5 ♘xf5 15.♘xd4 cxd4 16.♙xa8 ♖xa8 17.♘e4± is what White is hoping for) 7.♙g2 ♘ge7 8.♘ge2 0-0 d5 ♖ Black may well be slightly better already.

5...♘c6 6.♙b2!N

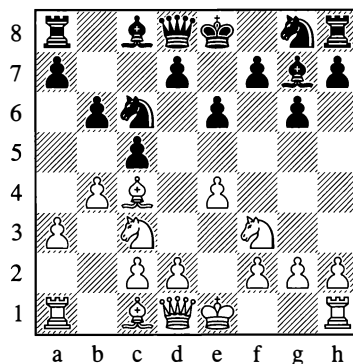
Probably the best way to sacrifice the b4-pawn.

On 6.♖b1, holding on to the pawn, the best reply is:



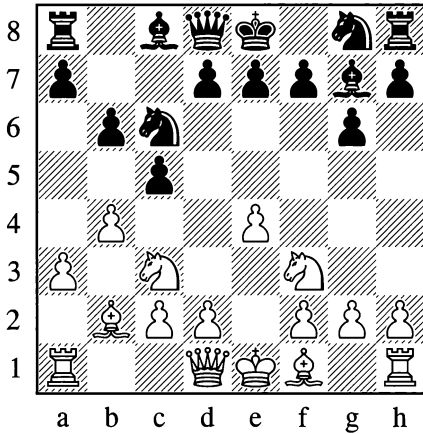
6...♘f6! 7.bxc5 (7.b5 ♘d4 8.e5 ♘h5!± is fine for Black) 7...bxc5 8.♙b5!? (8.♙c4! 0-0 9.0-0 d6 ♖ 8...♘d4!? (8...0-0 9.♙xc6 dxc6 10.0-0 ♙g4 11.♖e1 ♘d7 12.h3 ♙xf3 13.♖xf3±) 9.e5 ♘g4 10.♘xd4 cxd4 11.♖xg4 dxc3∞ Black has a fully playable game.

After 6.♙c4 e6! the bishop on c4 bites on granite! For example:



7.0-0 ♘ge7 8.d4?! (8.bxc5 bxc5 9.♖b1 is preferable) 8...cxd4 9.♘b5 0-0 10.♘bxd4 ♘xd4 11.♘xd4 ♙b7 ♖ Black had the better pawn structure, as well as the more harmonious development, in Dobrov – Aroshidze, Kavala 2004.





**6...e5!**

With the bishop on b2 this looks like the strategically correct move.

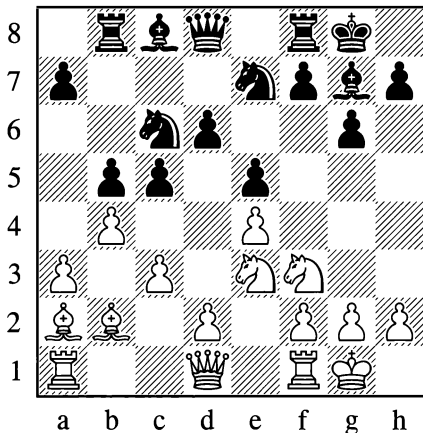
6...cxb4 7.axb4 ♖xb4 8.♙c4∞ is unclear.

**7.♙c4 ♜ge7 8.0-0 0-0 9.♜d5 d6=**

The computers are happy to be White here, which is difficult to understand as the b2-bishop is inactive. The position is approximately balanced: Black intends ...♞b8, followed by ...b5 and/or a timely capture on d5. A sample line is:

**10.c3 ♞b8 11.♜e3 b5 12.♙a2**

**12.♙e2 f5↑**



**12...a5 13.bxc5 dxc5 14.a4 b4 15.♞e2 ♙d7**  
**16.♙c4**

**16.h4!? ♜c8∞**

**16...♜c8**

The computer finally agrees that Black stands well, and obviously his position is more pleasant from the human perspective in view of the protected passed pawn on b4.

## Conclusion

The 2nd move options examined in this chapter are not in any way theoretically dangerous for Black, but some may require careful memorization of details. Throughout the chapter I tried to give sound recommendations without jeopardizing our winning chances, and I am particularly satisfied with the results. Overall, an engrossing chapter with many interesting ideas for Black, which I hope will enhance the readers' winning ways.